

MA HONGXIA

PERSONAL INFORMATION

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EDUCATION

National University of Singapore

2020 – 2026

Ph.D. in Economics, expected August 2026

Supervisor: Julian Wright

National University of Singapore

2016 - 2020

B.Sc. (Honours) in Statistics, First Class; Second Major in Economics

RESEARCH FIELDS

Platform and digital economics, Industrial organization, Applied microeconomic theory

WORKING PAPERS

Focality Dynamics and Platform Competition

Draft available upon request

We study how the evolution of consumer beliefs over time shapes dynamic competition between two vertically differentiated platforms in the presence of network effects, using the notion of partial focality. We develop a tractable model in which focality evolves with past market outcomes according to an exponentially weighted moving average rule. Asymmetries in platforms' focality dynamics are captured by differences in their initial focality levels and in the persistence of their focality advantages. We show that when focality adjusts more slowly to recent market outcomes, both market efficiency and consumer surplus decrease. Greater platform patience improves market efficiency only if the quality gap between the platforms is sufficiently large. Finally, we allow platforms to make initial marketing investments that affect either initial focality or the persistence of focality dynamics. Under either channel, the high-quality platform has a stronger incentive to invest in marketing than the low-quality platform.

Presentations: Platform Strategy Research Symposium (Boston University), 2026; Asian Game Theory Conference, 2026 (forthcoming); INFORMS Job Market Showcase, 2026 (forthcoming).

How Network Effects Shape Firm Entry Strategies

Draft available upon request

There is a common presumption that network effects intensify firms' race to enter first as they seek to secure an incumbency advantage. We explore this possibility in an infinite-horizon model in which two vertically differentiated firms decide whether and when to enter a growing market. Incumbency advantage arises endogenously from consumer beliefs in the post-entry pricing subgame: whenever multiple equilibria exist, consumers coordinate on a focal firm. We compare alternative specifications of focality dynamics. When focality is locked into the first entrant, network effects indeed amplify inefficient early entry. However, when focality adapts quickly to recent market outcomes, network effects can instead mitigate premature entry for sufficiently patient firms by weakening the low-quality firm's preemption incentive. This effect can be surprisingly pronounced in a growing market. When firms are sufficiently patient and network effects are sufficiently strong, adaptive focality can tilt the entry race in favor of the high-quality firm even more than a focality structure that always favors it.

Presentations: Asia-Pacific Industrial Organization Conference (APIOC), 2024; NUS Microeconomic Theory Reading Group; NTU Brown Bag Seminar.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Price coherence when consumers have differential shopping costs

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

NUS Department of Economics, Teaching assistant

Sem 2, AY2021/22 - Sem 2, AY2023/24

EC3102 Macroeconomics Analysis II (teaching evaluation: 4.2/5)

AWARDS & SCHOLARSHIPS

NUS Research Scholarship

Dean's List from Department of Statistics (NUS) for Undergraduates

NUS Science & Technology Undergraduate Scholarship

SM2 Scholarship from Singapore's Ministry of Education (MOE)

SKILLS

Computing R, Python, MATLAB

Language Mandarin (Native), English (Fluent), Japanese (Beginner)

REFERENCES

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